

3 Minute Breathing Space

The **3-Minute Breathing Space** teaches us important skills.¹ First, we learn to give our physical bodies permission to talk to us; second, we learn to notice our breathing; and third, we learn that mindful breathing helps us experience ourselves as unified material and spiritual creatures. The **3-Minute Breathing Space** trains us to connect to our breathing when we are under stress and, also, disconnect from our compulsive judgments, reactions, and stories. We can simply breathe and observe.

We start with **AWARENESS**.

Prepare your body for mindfulness practice. Sit up straight, if you can. Think of the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Lengthen your spine by straightening the back of your neck and drop your chin a little. Plant your feet on the ground or, if you are sitting on the floor, plant your tailbone into the earth. If possible, close your eyes. Then ask yourself: *What is my experience right now—in thoughts, in feelings, and in my body's sensations?* (Repeat) Get to know yourself as you are right now. Observe for one minute, and breathe. (Pause for 1 minute)

Move to **GATHERING**.

Gently bring your full attention to your breath, just as it is, watching each in-breath and each out-breath as they follow one after the other. Use your breath as an anchor to bring you into the present moment and to help you find a place of stillness and unbiased awareness. Observe your breathing without judgment and release any thoughts of right or wrong. Breathe and observe for one minute. (Pause for 1 minute)

Now move to **EXPANDING**.

Expand your awareness to include a sense of yourself as a composite whole of mind, emotions, and physical sensations, including the part of you that is observing all of those things. (Pause) Notice how your body moves with each breath. (Pause) Notice your posture and what your face is doing. (Pause) Observe and breathe for one minute. (Pause 1 minute)

Now pause. It takes a long time to learn how to make the most of the **3-Minute Breathing Space**, and most of us are still learning. Be kind to yourself as you train and learn.

We practice mindfulness to maintain our awareness of who we are and what we are experiencing in the present moment, no matter what is going on around us. Try to set aside time in the morning and then again later in the day. It might help to attach this practice to a habit that is already in place.

Take a deep breath.

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams, and John D. Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.